

ONE LAST CALL

CLAYVON'TE BROACH



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One Last Call

Story of one last phone call after passing



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Foreword

This story began with a question: What does it mean to give everything?

One Last Call is not just a thriller. It's a reckoning. A collision of loyalty, grief, and redemption. It follows Elijah Ward — a man of precision, silence, and sacrifice — as he faces an impossible choice. And it follows Marcus, his brother, spiraling through recklessness and regret, forced to confront the cost of absence when it's too late to undo it.

At its core, this book is about the weight of legacy. About the moments that define us when no one is watching. About the people we fail, the promises we break, and the rare, brutal beauty of choosing someone else over ourselves.

You'll find action here — cliff dives, wing suits, silent take-downs, and indestructible devices. But you'll also find heart-break. A phone ringing on a bathroom floor. A name glowing on the screen. A scream that splits the silence.

This is a story for anyone who's ever lost someone they didn't know how to hold onto. For anyone who's ever made a promise they couldn't keep — and for those who still believe in second chances, even when they come too late.

Elijah's final act wasn't just a mission. It was a message. And this book is the echo of that call.

— Boardwalk Clay

I

“It’s never too late”

1

Chapter 1

The door slammed behind him with a force that rattled the frame, the sound echoing down the quiet street like a gunshot. Marcus stormed out into the night, his boots striking the pavement with heavy, deliberate steps. Each stride carried the weight of anger, pride, and whiskey. His breath came in sharp bursts, visible in the cold air, as if even the night itself recoiled from his fury.

“Always Elijah,” he muttered, his voice low but venomous. “Always answering him, always listening to him. Like he’s the one who knows better than me. Like he’s perfect.”

He shoved his hands deep into his jacket pockets, shoulders tense, jaw clenched so tight it ached. The streetlights painted him in long shadows, highlighting the sharp lines of his face — handsome, muscular, tall, dark-skinned, the kind of man who turned heads without trying. He looked so much like Elijah that strangers often mistook them for twins, but where Elijah’s calm drew people in, Marcus’s storm pushed them away.

“And Latrice,” he spat, shaking his head as he walked faster.

“Always telling me to leave. Always pushing me out. Like I’m the problem. Like I’m not the one who stayed.”

His voice rose, echoing off the brick walls of the buildings around him. He laughed bitterly, the sound hollow, jagged. “Elijah runs off to play soldier, to play genius, and somehow he’s the hero. I’m the one who works, the one who pays, the one who bleeds for this life. But no — I’m the villain. I’m the drunk. I’m the one she tells to get out.”

Marcus’s fists tightened inside his pockets, knuckles white against the fabric. He wanted to turn back, to slam the door open and shout until Latrice understood. He wanted to remind her of the nights he carried her when she was too tired to stand, the mornings he rose before dawn to swing an axe, to cut timber, to earn the money that kept their lives afloat. But pride kept him moving forward. Pride and the burn of liquor in his veins.

“Fine,” he muttered, his voice breaking into a growl. “She wants me gone? I’ll be gone. I’ll show her. I’ll show both of them.”

The night swallowed his words as he headed toward the bar, the neon glow in the distance promising escape, indulgence, and the kind of reckless freedom that always came at a price. His stride grew looser, his anger feeding into a dangerous confidence. He was handsome, magnetic, the kind of man who could walk into a room and command it — but tonight, that magnetism was poisoned by resentment.

The city hummed around him, cars rushing past, laughter spilling from open doors, music pulsing from hidden corners. Marcus barely noticed. All he saw was the bar ahead, its lights flickering like a beacon for the lost. He pushed the door open, the smell of alcohol and sweat rushing out to meet him.

Inside, the world shifted. The noise, the bodies, the promise

CHAPTER 1

of forgetting — it was all there, waiting. Marcus squared his shoulders, his storm carried with him, ready to drown in the night.

Chapter 2

The neon lights painted Marcus in shades of red and blue as he leaned against the counter, whiskey glass in hand. He was tall, dark-skinned, muscular — the kind of man whose presence filled a room. His resemblance to Elijah was uncanny, but where Elijah's calm steadied people, Marcus's storm pulled them into the fire.

The two women he had spotted earlier drifted closer, their laughter already loose from the drinks they'd had before. Marcus waved the bartender over, his grin wide and confident. "Another round. Put theirs on me."

The curly-haired woman squealed with delight, clinking her empty glass against his. "You're too good to us," she slurred, her words already wobbling.

The sharp-eyed one smirked, leaning in. "Careful. We'll drink you under the table."

Marcus chuckled, his voice booming. "Not a chance."

The drinks arrived, and the three of them dove in. One round became two, then three. The curly-haired woman tipped her

glass too far, spilling liquor down her dress, laughing so hard she nearly fell off her stool. Marcus caught her, steadying her with one strong arm, and she clung to him, giggling uncontrollably.

The sharp-eyed woman wasn't far behind. She tried to stand, swaying dangerously, her heel catching on the floor. She stumbled into Marcus, knocking his glass from his hand. Whiskey splashed across the bar, the smell sharp and heavy. Marcus laughed, pulling her upright, but her eyes were glassy, her words tumbling out in fragments.

Soon, the three of them were a spectacle. They shouted over the music, their laughter too loud, their bodies too unsteady. The curly-haired woman tripped over a stool, crashing into a table and sending silverware clattering to the floor. The sharp-eyed one leaned against Marcus, her head heavy on his shoulder, mumbling secrets she'd regret in the morning.

Marcus himself was no better. His words slurred, his swagger loosened, his movements heavy. He ordered another round, slamming bills onto the counter, his pride refusing to admit defeat.

The bartender shook his head, muttering under his breath. The bar owner finally approached, his face stern, his patience gone. "That's enough. You all need to leave. Now."

Marcus didn't argue. He pulled out his wallet, thick with cash from weeks of lumberjack work. He slapped down four crisp hundreds, covering the chaos they had caused. "Keep the change," he muttered, his voice steady despite the haze in his eyes.

The women gasped at the gesture, impressed by his generosity even in their drunken stupor. "You're something else," the curly-haired one said, her words slurred, her smile crooked.

Marcus grinned, his pride swelling. "Come on. The night's

not over yet.”

Chapter 3

The nights had grown longer in Latrice's house, not because of the ticking clock but because of Marcus's drinking. The smell of whiskey clung to the walls like a second coat of paint, seeping into the curtains, the carpet, even her skin. She had stopped counting the bottles weeks ago; they multiplied faster than her patience could keep track.

Marcus stumbled through the doorway, his boots heavy against the hardwood, his eyes glazed with the dull shine of liquor. Latrice sat at the kitchen table, her scrubs still on from a twelve-hour shift, exhaustion etched into her face. She didn't look up when he entered; silence had become her shield.

"Don't start," Marcus muttered, dropping his keys with a clatter. His voice was thick, defensive, already bracing for a fight.

"I wasn't going to," Latrice replied softly, though her tone carried the weight of every unspoken word. She wanted to scream, to shake him, to demand the man she fell in love with return. But she knew better.

He poured another drink, ignoring the way her eyes followed the amber liquid. "It helps me think," he said, as if rehearsing an excuse he'd used a hundred times.

"It helps you forget," she corrected, her voice trembling. "And it helps us fall apart."

The silence that followed was heavier than the argument itself. Marcus stared at her, jaw tight, but said nothing. Latrice turned away, her heart aching with the knowledge that love alone could not save him.

Then Marcus's phone buzzed on the counter. The screen lit up with a name that froze them both: Elijah Ward.

Marcus glanced at it, his hand tightening around the glass. He let the phone ring, muttering under his breath, "Not tonight." He turned the device face down, drowning the call in whiskey.

But the call didn't die. It rerouted, vibrating against Latrice's palm where her own phone lay. She hesitated, then answered.

"Elijah?" she whispered.

Static hummed softly, then his voice came through — low, calm, almost casual. "Hey, Latrice. I figured Marcus wouldn't pick up. Thought maybe you would."

His tone was cool, relaxed, the opposite of Marcus's storm. No urgency, no judgment — just a steady presence that filled the room.

Marcus scoffed, turning away. "Always calling at the worst times."

Elijah chuckled lightly, the sound carrying a strange ease. "Or maybe the right times. You two fight too much. I'm just here to remind you it doesn't have to be this way."

Latrice pressed the phone tighter to her ear, her pulse quickening. "It's been months, Elijah. Where have you been?"

"Working," he said simply. "Far away. Dangerous things. But

I still know my brother. I still know when he's hurting. And I know when you're hurting too."

Marcus slammed his glass down. "You don't know a damn thing. You left. You don't get to call in and play savior."

Elijah's voice didn't rise. It stayed steady, almost soothing. "I didn't leave forever, Marcus. I'm still here. And I'll always call when I know you're about to lose something you can't get back."

The words hung in the air, heavy with meaning. Latrice felt her throat tighten. "We're falling apart, Elijah. I don't know how much longer I can do this."

"You can," Elijah said softly. "Because you're stronger than he knows. And Marcus... you're stronger than you let yourself believe. But strength isn't in the bottle. It's in the people who love you. Don't push them away."

Marcus turned his back, shoulders rigid, refusing to answer. Latrice's eyes burned with tears she refused to let fall.

"Elijah," she whispered, her voice breaking. "What if it's already too late?"

There was a pause, then his reply — calm, certain, almost chilling in its simplicity:

"It's never too late."

Chapter 4

“**I**t’s never too late.”

Elijah let the words hang in the air before ending the call. He always said it, not just because it was his mother’s mantra, but because it reminded him of her faith in him. She had whispered those words when he was a boy hunched over puzzles, locks, and machines, determined to prove he could solve anything. It’s never too late, Elijah. Not for you. Not for the world you want to change.

Since her passing, Elijah had carried that phrase into every mission. It became his ritual: before stepping into danger, he would call home. Sometimes Marcus, sometimes Latrice. He never explained why, never admitted that it was his way of saying goodbye in case he didn’t return. Nobody knew the truth — that each call was a tether, a final thread tying him to the people he loved most.

From the time he was a boy, Elijah’s mind worked differently. Where Marcus saw obstacles, Elijah saw systems. He could take apart a lock and rebuild it blindfolded, not because he wanted to

break rules, but because he wanted to understand how things fit together. His mother encouraged it, buying him puzzles, safes, and mechanical kits. She would laugh as he explained the math behind a six-digit code — “There are a million possible combinations, Mom, but there’s always a way through.”

It wasn’t just locks. Elijah had a gift for wiring, for seeing electricity as veins of light running through machines. He could rewire a radio to pick up signals from miles away, build a motor from scraps, or fix a broken appliance with nothing more than a screwdriver and intuition. By the time he was a teenager, he was designing contraptions that blended mechanics and electronics — crude prototypes of drones, surveillance devices, and communication tools.

He was a natural mechanical engineer, though he never had the title. He could sketch blueprints in the dirt with a stick, then bring them to life with whatever parts he scavenged. His teachers called him restless; his mother called him brilliant.

That brilliance didn’t go unnoticed. Quietly, Elijah was recruited into the military. Not as a soldier with a rifle, but as a ghost in the system — a man who could dismantle bombs, rewire circuits under fire, improvise tools from scraps, and infiltrate places others couldn’t. He became the one they called when missions required silence, precision, and ingenuity.

Now Elijah stood alone, preparing for another mission. This one was different. Classified, dangerous, and solitary. No team, no backup. Just him, his tools, and the weight of what he carried.

The wind howled around him as he stood at the edge of a cliff, wing suit stretched across his arms like a second skin. Below, the valley was a black ocean of shadows, the kind of terrain only someone like him would dare to cross. He checked his gear with mechanical precision — straps tightened, wiring secured,

oxygen steady. Every detail mattered. Every detail could mean the difference between life and death.

He inhaled, steady and calm. Then he leapt.

The wing suit caught the wind, snapping open like a bird's embrace. He dove into the darkness, slicing through the air, the mission unfolding beneath him. Somewhere far below, danger waited. Somewhere far above, his mother's words followed him like a prayer.

It's never too late.

II

“Too Much”

5

Chapter 5

The call had ended, but the silence it left behind was louder than any argument. Latrice lowered the phone slowly, her hand trembling, her heart still racing from Elijah's voice. Marcus stood across the room, glass in hand, his jaw tight with anger.

"You always answer him," Marcus snapped, his words slurred but sharp. "Every damn time. Like he's the one who knows better than me."

Latrice's eyes burned, but she held her ground. "Because he does, Marcus. He sees what you're doing to yourself. To us."

Marcus laughed bitterly, a hollow sound that filled the kitchen. "You think Elijah's perfect? He left. He ran off to play soldier, to play genius, while I stayed here. I'm the one who kept this life together. Not him."

"You're tearing it apart," Latrice shot back, her voice rising. "Every night it's the same. The drinking, the excuses, the anger. And when Elijah calls, it's the only time I feel like someone's trying to save us."

Marcus slammed his glass down, the sound cracking through the room. "Save us? He's not here, Latrice. He's never here. It's just me. And you don't want me anymore, do you?"

Her chest tightened, the weight of his words pressing down. She wanted to tell him she did love him, that she always had, but the truth was tangled in exhaustion and disappointment. "I want you sober. I want you present. I want the man I fell in love with, not this."

Marcus's face twisted, torn between rage and hurt. He grabbed his jacket from the chair, his movements clumsy but determined. "Fine. I'll go. That's what you want, isn't it? You always tell me to leave. Every time we fight, every time I drink. You push me out like I'm nothing."

Latrice's voice softened, though her resolve stayed firm. "Just for tonight, Marcus. Please. Go clear your head. Come back tomorrow. We'll talk then."

He shook his head, muttering under his breath as he pulled the door open. "Tomorrow. Always tomorrow. You'll see. I'll be back. You'll regret telling me to leave."

The door slammed, and the house fell into silence. Latrice sat at the table, staring at the phone still glowing faintly in her hand.

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Chapter 6

The air roared past him as he spread his arms, the fabric catching the wind. He glided like a hawk, slicing through the night sky, his body steady, his mind focused. The cliff receded behind him, the compound ahead growing larger with every second. He angled his descent, skimming the treetops before pulling into a controlled dive.

At the last moment, he tucked his arms and rolled, hitting the ground with precision. He slid across the dirt, the wing suit folding around him as he packed it swiftly, tucking it into a compartment on his back. No wasted movement, no hesitation. He was already moving toward the water.

The river was cold, biting against his skin as he slipped beneath its surface. He swam silently, his strokes long and powerful, his lungs steady. Minutes passed as he pushed forward, the current dragging at him, but Elijah was relentless. He surfaced only once for air, then dove again, disappearing into the dark.

When he emerged near the compound's dock, three guards stood watch, rifles slung casually, their attention scattered. Eli-

jah pressed himself against the shadows, his breath controlled, his body still. He moved like a phantom, rising from the water without a sound.

The first guard fell before he realized anyone was there — Elijah's arm snapping around his throat, pulling him into silence. The second turned, confused, but Elijah was already on him, striking with precision, dropping him to the ground. The third barely had time to raise his weapon before Elijah's hand clamped over his mouth, dragging him backward into the dark. Three guards gone. No alarms raised.

Elijah exhaled slowly, his eyes scanning the perimeter. Then he reached into his pack and pulled out the device — the one he had built himself, the one no one else could replicate. It was sleek, compact, its surface gleaming faintly under the moonlight. He pressed a button, and the device hummed to life, sending out invisible waves that mapped the area around him.

The screen lit up with outlines — guards, cameras, hidden tripwires. Every detail appeared in perfect clarity. The device was indestructible, forged from materials Elijah had tested against fire, water, and impact. It was his creation, his edge, the tool that made him untouchable.

He held it steady, scanning the compound, his mind already calculating his next move. The guards were down, the perimeter mapped, the path ahead clear. He headed for the target compound with only a steel door between him and the objective.

Chapter 7

The steel chamber was silent when Elijah entered, the hum of hidden machinery vibrating faintly through the walls. On the table sat a single folded note.

He reached out, lifted it — and the trap snapped shut.

Red beams erupted from the walls, crisscrossing into a cage of light. The lasers locked around him, tightening like restraints. His arms froze at his sides, his chest pinned by the grid. He could barely move, the beams calibrated to hold him in place. Only his right hand had a sliver of freedom, enough to reach but not enough to escape.

Elijah's jaw tightened, but his pulse stayed steady. He unfolded the note.

The handwriting was sharp, deliberate, signed by **Darius Korr**, the mercenary whose name haunted dossiers across continents.

Elijah Ward. Age 32. Twin brother Marcus. Companion Latrice. You think you are unseen, but I see you. You think you are untouchable, but I touch everything you love. The lasers hold you now. The switch

to cut them off is on the far wall. Without help, you will never reach it. Without invention, you will never survive.

Elijah's eyes flicked to the wall. The switch was there, glowing faintly behind the lattice of beams. Impossible to reach without triggering detonation.

But Elijah wasn't worried.

He shifted his free hand toward his belt, fingers brushing against the small, sleek device he had built himself. It was one of his secrets, one of the reasons he was so good. He turned it to the "radio light" function, A radio-frequency jammer — not for sound, not for communication, but for light.

He had been working with radio frequencies since he was a boy, fascinated by the invisible waves that carried voices and signals. Over the years, he had bent them, layered them, manipulated them until they could interfere with things no one else thought possible. He had discovered that certain frequencies could disrupt the coherence of light itself, scattering beams, weakening lasers.

The device in his hand was the culmination of years of obsession. A compact emitter tuned to frequencies that destabilized light grids. To anyone else, it was science fiction. To Elijah, it was just another puzzle solved.

He pressed the switch.

The jammer hummed, releasing a pulse that rippled through the chamber. The lasers flickered, their grip loosening. The cage of light wavered, beams scattering just enough to give him room to move.

Elijah smirked, the same way he had when his mother handed him safes with six-digit codes. "This won't be an issue," he whispered.

He stepped forward, weaving through the weakened beams, his body precise, his movements calculated. He reached the wall, his hand steady as he flipped the switch.

The lasers died. The hum faded. The trap was broken.

Elijah stood in the silence, the note still in his hand, the device warm against his palm. He wasn't shaken. He wasn't afraid. This was why he was the best. Because he had secrets no one else could imagine. Because he had mastered frequencies that others didn't even know existed.

And because he was always prepared for traps like this.

8

Chapter 8

Marcus burst out of the bar into the cool night air, his laughter echoing down the street. The two women clung to his arms, their heels clicking unevenly against the pavement as they stumbled beside him. Neon lights painted their faces in streaks of pink and blue, the city alive with music and motion.

The curly-haired woman was radiant, her smile wide and unrestrained, her eyes sparkling even through the haze of alcohol. She leaned into Marcus, giggling, her perfume sweet and intoxicating. The sharp-eyed one was striking in her own way — tall, poised even in her drunken sway, her gaze sharp enough to cut through the night. Together, they were magnetic, their beauty amplified by the chaos of the evening.

Marcus swaggered down the street, his broad shoulders and muscular frame commanding attention. He was handsome, dark-skinned, tall — the kind of man who turned heads without effort. Like Elijah, he carried the kind of presence that drew people in, but his storm burned hotter, reckless and untamed.

They stopped at a corner shop, Marcus pulling out his wallet with a grin. "What do you want? Snacks? More drinks?" he asked, his voice booming. The women laughed, pointing at bottles of wine, chocolates, anything that caught their eye. Marcus bought it all, piling bags into their arms, his pride swelling with every purchase.

On the way to the hotel, they flirted shamelessly. The curly-haired woman teased him, brushing her hand against his chest, marveling at the strength beneath his shirt. The sharp-eyed one whispered in his ear, daring him to keep the night alive. Marcus reveled in it, his grin wide, his confidence unshaken.

Finally, they reached the Grand Veymar Hotel, its glass facade shimmering like a jewel against the night sky. The marble lobby gleamed under chandeliers, polished floors reflecting their drunken steps. Marcus strode to the desk, the women giggling behind him, their beauty drawing stares from guests and staff alike.

"Presidential suite," he demanded, his voice slurred but commanding.

The clerk hesitated, but Marcus slapped down his card, grinning. "Don't worry. I can afford it."

Moments later, the elevator carried them upward, the women leaning against him, whispering promises of a night without end.

The doors swung open to reveal a palace in the sky. Velvet couches stretched across the room, gold-trimmed mirrors reflected the city lights, and a balcony overlooked the sprawling streets below. Marcus threw his arms wide, triumphant. "This," he declared, "is how you live."

The women gasped, their eyes wide with delight. The curly-haired one spun barefoot across the marble, her laughter ringing

like music. The sharp-eyed one leaned against the balcony, her silhouette framed by the city lights, her beauty undeniable.

Marcus grinned, his storm consuming the night. He had led them here, into luxury, into chaos, into legend.

III

“Baby?”

Chapter 9

The house was quiet, too quiet. Latrice sat at the edge of the bed, her hands folded tightly in her lap, staring at the shadows stretching across the walls. Marcus hadn't come home. Again.

Her chest ached with worry, the kind that gnawed at her bones. She thought of him at the bar, his laughter too loud, his swagger too reckless. He had been drinking more since his mother passed, drowning himself in whiskey and beer, as if the burn could erase the grief. Latrice had tried to reach him, to pull him back, but every attempt ended in shouting, in slammed doors, in silence.

She whispered into the empty room, "You're not the same, Marcus. You're slipping away."

Her stomach twisted, not just from worry but from something deeper. For weeks she hadn't felt right — dizzy spells, exhaustion, a heaviness she couldn't shake. Tonight, with Marcus gone and the silence pressing in, she decided she couldn't ignore it any longer.

She rose slowly, her bare feet brushing against the cool floor, and walked to the bathroom. The mirror reflected her tired eyes, the faint lines of stress etched across her face. She opened the cabinet, her hands trembling as she pulled out the small box she had hidden days ago.

A pregnancy test.

Her breath caught. She hadn't wanted to face this, not yet. Not with Marcus spiraling, not with their lives unraveling. But the truth pressed against her, demanding to be seen.

She tore open the box, her fingers clumsy, her heart pounding. The minutes stretched into eternity as she waited, the silence broken only by the ticking of the clock in the hallway.

Finally, she looked down.

Two lines.

Positive.

Her knees buckled, and she sank to the floor, the test clutched in her hand. Tears blurred her vision, spilling down her cheeks. She pressed her forehead against the cool tile, whispering, "Oh God... Marcus."

The weight of it crushed her. She was carrying his child. A new life, fragile and unasked for, growing inside her. And Marcus was out there, lost in liquor, reckless in his grief, burning through the money they had saved for their future.

She thought of his mother, the woman who had held their family together, whose death had shattered Marcus in ways he couldn't admit. She thought of Elijah, steady and disciplined, the twin who seemed to carry the strength Marcus had abandoned. And she thought of herself, alone in the quiet, holding the secret that would change everything.

Her tears slowed, replaced by a fierce determination. She pressed the test against her chest, whispering to the child she

now knew was there. "I'll protect you. No matter what. Even if he can't."

But deep inside, fear gnawed at her. Fear of Marcus's drinking, fear of his recklessness, fear of what tomorrow would bring when he finally stumbled home.

The silence of the house pressed in again, heavy and suffocating. Latrice sat there on the bathroom floor, clutching the test, her heart torn between love and dread.

Tomorrow, she thought, she would tell him. Tomorrow.

Chapter 10

The chamber was silent now, the first cage of lasers gone. Elijah moved with precision, his boots whispering against the concrete as he crossed to the far corner. There, half-hidden behind a steel console, sat the real bomb — its casing gleaming faintly, wires coiled like veins waiting to pulse.

He crouched, his night vision goggles painting the device in ghostly green. His jaw tightened, his breath steady. One hand reached forward, cutting the red wire nearest the floor. Then the green crossing the left beam. Then the yellow above. Finally, the black beneath the console.

Each snip was deliberate, surgical. The hum faded, the bomb's deadly heart silenced.

Elijah rose, his body calm, his mind already turning toward the steel door. He took a few steps forward, hand reaching for the handle.

That was when the chamber erupted.

Dozens of lasers snapped into existence at once, red beams

slicing through the air in every direction. They locked him instantly, freezing him mid-step, his arm stretched toward the door, his body caught in the act of escape. The grid was absolute — beams across his chest, his legs, his arms, even his throat. He couldn't move. Not an inch. Not enough to reach the device at his belt this time.

The speakers crackled overhead.

"Elijah Ward," the mercenary's voice drawled, deep and mocking. "I knew you'd escape the first trap. That was the decoy. This is the real one."

A mechanical whir filled the chamber. A panel slid open, and a screen descended from the ceiling. Static flickered, then sharpened into a live feed.

Elijah's breath caught.

It was Marcus's house.

But Marcus wasn't there.

The camera showed Latrice, alone, moving through the quiet rooms. Elijah's chest tightened as he watched her sit on the bathroom floor, clutching something in her hand. The feed zoomed closer, revealing the pregnancy test. Two lines. Positive.

The mercenary's voice cut through the silence, deliberate and cruel. "You see, Elijah, I know everything. Your age. Your brother's name. Latrice. And now, her secret. She is carrying his child. A child who will inherit his recklessness... or your discipline. But only if she lives."

The lasers hummed, their grip unyielding. Elijah's muscles strained, but the beams held him fast, locking him in the exact position he had been caught — walking, reaching for the door, frozen in time.

"You have a choice," the mercenary said. "Let the house explode — and Latrice dies. Or blow yourself up here, and she

lives. One life for another. One sacrifice for survival.”

The video feed remained, Latrice’s face illuminated by the bathroom light, her tears glistening as she whispered to herself. Elijah could hear her words faintly through the speaker: “*I’ll protect you. No matter what.*”

Elijah’s jaw clenched, his eyes burning with fury. His invention had saved him once, but now it was useless, locked beyond reach. The mercenary had anticipated him, had studied him, had built a trap designed not to test his skill but to break his heart.

The screen flickered, Latrice’s image frozen in place, her secret laid bare. Elijah’s pulse thundered against the cage of light.

“This won’t be an issue,” he whispered, though his voice trembled now. “Not for me.”

But for the first time, Elijah wasn’t sure if he believed it.

Chapter 11

Marcus had bought this moment, paid for it in full, and he intended to drown in it.

Champagne bottles popped, corks ricocheting off the walls. Trays of food arrived in waves—steaks dripping with butter, seafood piled high, desserts stacked like towers. Marcus ordered more, laughing as the women danced barefoot across the marble, spilling wine onto carpets worth more than his truck. He kept spending, kept feeding the storm inside him, as if each indulgence could erase the ache left by his mother's death.

The curly-haired woman spun toward him, her curls bouncing, her laughter ringing like music. She pressed herself against him, her lips brushing his neck, daring him to respond. The sharp-eyed one leaned in from the other side, her gaze daring, her hand sliding across his chest, whispering promises that blurred into the haze of liquor.

Marcus flirted shamelessly, his hands lingering too long, his words too bold. Latrice's face flickered in his mind, but the whiskey drowned it out. *She pushed me away*, he told himself. *She told me to leave. Elijah's the one she listens to, not me. So why*

shouldn't I? Why shouldn't I take what's offered?

The liquor twisted his thoughts, blurred his judgment, and silenced his conscience. He convinced himself it was justified, even as he crossed the line. The laughter softened into whispers, the lights dimmed, and the suite fell into a haze of closeness, the kind that left no doubt about what had happened.

Hours later, silence blanketed the room. The curly-haired woman lay tangled in the sheets, her curls spread across the pillow. The sharp-eyed one was draped across the couch, her sharpness dulled by exhaustion. Marcus sprawled across the bed, his chest rising and falling heavily, his mind fogged with liquor.

The air reeked of alcohol and sweat, the remnants of indulgence. Bottles rolled across the floor, glasses shattered, food untouched. Marcus closed his eyes, whispering to himself in the haze. *It wasn't me. It was the liquor. Tomorrow, it'll be fine. Tomorrow, she'll forgive me.*

But tomorrow was already slipping away.

Chapter 12

L atrice sat on the edge of the bed, the pregnancy test still fresh in her mind, its two faint lines burning into her thoughts. The weight of it pressed against her chest, heavy and unrelenting. A baby. Marcus's child. Their child. The realization sent her into a small panic, her breath quickening as her hands trembled. She reached for her phone, dialing Marcus with urgency, needing his voice, needing him to share in the storm that had just broken inside her.

The call rang. Once. Twice. Over and over. No answer.

Her heart sank. She tried again, whispering his name as if he might hear it through the static. Still nothing. The silence on the other end was louder than any reply.

She pressed the phone to her chest, closing her eyes. Guilt washed over her, sharp and sudden. What if something happened to him? What if he's hurt? The thought twisted her stomach. She wanted to be angry, wanted to demand where he was, but instead she found herself hoping he was safe, hoping he was just out blowing off steam, hoping he would walk through the door and hold her the way he used to.

But the door stayed closed.

Finally, exhausted, she slid beneath the covers. The house was too quiet, the shadows too long. She reached for the small teddy bear Marcus had bought her months ago, a silly gift that had somehow become her comfort. She clutched it tightly, pressing it against her chest, whispering to the child she now knew was there. "I'll protect you. No matter what."

Her tears slowed, replaced by a fragile calm. She drifted into sleep, holding the bear, oblivious to the dangers circling her home, oblivious to the mercenary's trap already in motion.

Chapter 13

Elijah stood locked in place, the lasers pinning him mid-step, his arm stretched toward the steel door. The chamber hummed with their unyielding grip, red beams slicing across his body, freezing him in time. The mercenary's voice echoed, taunting, demanding a choice. But Elijah remained silent.

Hours passed. The mercenary grew impatient, his tone shifting from mockery to boredom. Finally, he laughed, his voice dripping with arrogance. "I'll leave the decision to you. I have a country to steal. Choose wisely." The speakers cut out, leaving Elijah alone in the humming cage of light.

The screen above flickered, Latrice's image still there — clutching the teddy bear, whispering to herself, oblivious to the danger. Elijah's eyes burned as he watched her, his mind spiraling inward.

Would Marcus do this for me if he were in the same boat? The thought pressed hard against him. He answered himself quickly. No. He wouldn't. He'd be out drinking, laughing, living reckless. He wouldn't stand here, frozen, waiting to give his life for me.

The thought made him laugh, a dry, bitter sound in his head. Of course not. That's Marcus. That's who he is.

His mind drifted further, tracing the arc of his own life. I didn't think I'd go out like this. Not trapped in a cage of light, not with the world waiting for me to choose between myself and someone else. I thought it would be different. A fight. A mission. Something worthy. But this... this is how it ends.

The hum of the lasers filled the silence, steady and unrelenting. Elijah's thoughts circled, heavy but calm. He had lived a good life, fought hard, built things that mattered. And now, he stood here, knowing the choice he would make, even if no one else ever heard it.

The mercenary was gone. The feed remained. Latrice was still there, unaware. Elijah stayed locked in place, silent, his decision forming in the quiet of his own mind.

Chapter 14

Marcus woke to a pounding in his skull and the harsh glare of daylight spilling through the balcony windows. He blinked, disoriented, the suite around him eerily quiet. The laughter, the music, the chaos of the night before had vanished.

He sat up slowly, the sheets tangled around him, and realized the women were gone. The couch was empty, the floor littered with overturned bottles and half-eaten trays of food. His clothes were scattered, but his wallet was missing. His phone too.

On the desk, a folded slip of paper waited like a cruel reminder. He staggered over, picked it up, and stared at the numbers.

\$10,879.

The hotel bill.

Marcus's stomach dropped. He rifled through drawers, checked under cushions, searched the bathroom. Nothing. The women had taken everything — his cash, his cards, his phone. All that remained was the wreckage of indulgence and the crushing weight of debt.

He pressed his hands to his face, groaning. *What have I done?*

The liquor had whispered promises of escape, of justification, of indulgence. Now it left him with nothing but ruin.

By the time he stumbled out of the hotel, the sun was high overhead. Noon. The city was alive with traffic and chatter, but Marcus moved through it like a ghost, his head pounding, his body heavy. He had no money, no phone, no way to call home. Only his legs to carry him back.

Each step was slow, dragging, the weight of the night pressing harder with every block. He told himself he would explain, that tomorrow would fix everything.

But tomorrow was already slipping away.

Chapter 15

Latrice stirred awake to a heaviness in her body, the kind that made even the morning light feel sharp and intrusive. She sat up slowly, her stomach twisting, a wave of nausea rising before she could steady herself. She hurried to the bathroom, clutching the sink as her body betrayed her, the sickness spilling out in a way that left her weak and trembling.

When it passed, she rinsed her mouth, staring at her reflection in the mirror. Her skin was pale, her eyes tired, and yet there was something deeper in her expression — worry, fear, and a longing she couldn't shake. She pressed a hand against her stomach, whispering to herself, "I don't feel good... I need you, Marcus."

But the house was silent. The bed was still empty. He hadn't come home.

She leaned against the bathroom doorframe, her body heavy, her heart heavier. The sickness wasn't just physical; it was the ache of being alone, of needing him and finding only absence. She thought of calling again, but the phone lay useless on the

nightstand, unanswered from the night before.

Finally, she returned to bed, curling beneath the covers, clutching the teddy bear Marcus had once given her. She held it close, as if it could fill the space he had left behind. Her eyes closed, but sleep did not come easily. She lay there in the quiet, hoping he was safe, hoping he would walk through the door, hoping she wouldn't have to face this new weight alone.

And all the while, she remained oblivious — to the mercenary's trap already in motion, and to Marcus himself, miles away, lost in the haze of liquor and betrayal.

IV

“Farewell”

Chapter 16

Elijah's decision came without words, only the weight of his thoughts pressing against the silence. The lasers hummed, their red glow painting his body in lines of fire. He leaned forward, his fingers brushing the beam.

The chamber erupted.

First came the light — a blinding, searing flash that swallowed everything. It was not just brightness; it was the kind of light that erased shadows, erased form, erased the very memory of what had stood there. For an instant, the world was pure white, as if time itself had been scorched away.

Then came the sound. A roar that shook the steel walls, a thunderclap of finality. The explosion tore through the chamber, ripping metal from its foundations, scattering fragments like shrapnel into the void. The air itself seemed to scream as fire consumed the space where Elijah had stood.

And then, silence.

When the smoke cleared, there was nothing left of him. No body. No trace. Only the scorched imprint of sacrifice burned into the chamber's walls. Elijah Ward was gone — not vanished

quietly, but obliterated in a moment so fierce it demanded remembrance.

Far above, his beacon triggered, sending its signal into the sky. Satellites caught it, relays carried it, and the government team monitoring his mission froze as the alert appeared: Elijah Ward — lost in action.

The room fell into stunned silence. Officers stared at the console, caught off guard by the sudden loss of one of their most disciplined operatives. Shock rippled outward, heavy and undeniable. They knew what had to come next. His family had to be told.

And family meant Marcus.

Within minutes, black vehicles rolled out under the noon sun, their engines low and steady. A unit was dispatched to Marcus's house, carrying the weight of Elijah's sacrifice, carrying the news that would shatter the storm already brewing.

Elijah's final act was not quiet. It was a blaze, a roar, a memory carved into light and fire. A death that would be remembered — because he chose it, because he gave everything, because he made sure Latrice and his niece or nephew lived.

Chapter 17

The living room was heavy with silence, broken only by Marcus's ragged breathing and Latrice's quiet sobs. The officers stood solemnly, their uniforms immaculate, their faces carved with grief. One of them stepped forward, his voice steady but low.

"Elijah Ward was more than an agent," he began. "He was one of the most valuable minds this country has ever had. His intelligence, his precision, his ability to see what others could not... it made him indispensable. His loss is not just personal. It is detrimental to all of us."

Marcus's head snapped up, his eyes blazing through tears. "Detrimental?" His voice cracked, rising with fury. "You talk about him like he's just some words on a piece of paper. Like he's a report, a statistic, a damn file in your system. That was my brother! My blood! He wasn't just your 'most intelligent agent.' He was Elijah. He was mine!"

The room shook with his anger, his grief spilling out in waves. Latrice reached for him, her hand pressing against his arm, her

voice soft but firm. "Marcus... please. Don't. They're hurting too."

Her touch steadied him, her presence pulling him back from the edge. His chest heaved, his fists clenched, but he let her guide him down, his storm quieting just enough for the second officer to speak.

"Elijah was one of a kind," the man said, his voice thick with emotion. "He wasn't just an agent to us. He was family. We fought beside him, we trusted him, we depended on him. His loss cuts us just as deeply. Believe me when I say... we are just as hurt as you are."

Marcus's eyes softened, his fury giving way to sorrow. He nodded slowly, his tears falling freely now, his voice breaking. "He was my brother. My only brother."

The officers exchanged a look, then gestured toward the door. "There's something you need to have," one said quietly. "His personal effects. His valuables. They belong with you now."

Together, Marcus and Latrice followed them outside. The cold air bit against their skin, the black government vehicle waiting at the curb like a sentinel. One officer opened the rear compartment, revealing a sealed case. Inside lay Elijah's belongings — his watch, his notes, the device he had built, and a folded flag resting atop them.

Marcus's knees weakened at the sight. He reached out, his hands trembling, and lifted the watch, pressing it against his chest. Latrice stood beside him, her arm around his shoulders, her tears falling silently.

The officers remained close, one placing a hand on Marcus's shoulder, grounding him in the storm. "He gave everything," the man said softly. "And now, it's up to you to carry him forward."

Marcus closed his eyes, clutching Elijah's watch, his grief spilling into the night. Latrice held him tighter, and together they stood in the glow of the headlights, broken but bound by the memory of the man they had lost.

Would you like the next chapter to shift into Marcus reflecting on Elijah's sacrifice and what it means for him as a brother and soon-to-be father, or to follow the officers as they reveal more about Elijah's final mission and the mercenary's threat still looming?

Chapter 18

Marcus sat across from Latrice, his hands trembling as he tried to find the words. She was pale, her body heavy with exhaustion, her eyes filled with worry. She pressed a hand to her stomach and whispered, "I don't feel good. And I need you, Marcus. I need you to be here now. I need you to stop drinking. I can't do this alone."

Her voice cut through him sharper than any blade. He leaned forward, desperate, his words spilling out in a rush. "I'll be there. I swear it. No more drinking, no more running off. I'll change, Latrice. I'll change because of the baby. I'll be the man you need me to be. I'll be the father this child deserves."

She looked at him, her eyes steady despite the tears threatening to fall. "You've said that before. You've promised me before. And you didn't keep your word. Why should I believe you now?"

Marcus straightened, his voice firm, his tone carrying a conviction he hadn't shown in years. "Because it's different now. I see it. I feel it. I can't lose you. I can't lose this baby. I'll change, Latrice. I swear to you, I'll change."

Before she could answer, a thunderous knock rattled the front

door. The sound was sharp, urgent, echoing through the house. They froze, exchanging a look of concern.

“Were you expecting anyone?” Marcus asked, his voice low.

“No,” Latrice whispered.

The knock came again, louder this time, shaking the frame. They rushed to the door together, Marcus’s heart pounding. He pressed his hand against the wood, calling out, “Who is it?”

A commanding voice answered, firm and official. “United States government officers. It’s urgent. Open the door.”

Marcus hesitated, then pulled the door open. Three high-ranking officers stood in the doorway, their uniforms immaculate, their faces grave.

The moment Latrice saw them, her knees weakened. She knew. Tears spilled down her cheeks before a word was spoken.

Marcus turned, hearing her sobs, and the sound broke him instantly. He collapsed against the door frame, his voice erupting in a raw, guttural cry. “Elijah! Nooooo!” His scream tore through the house, echoing like a wound that would never heal.

Latrice fled down the hallway, her sobs trailing behind her, but moments later she returned, her face streaked with tears. She wrapped her arms around Marcus, holding him tight, her body trembling against his. He clung to her, his storm breaking into pieces in her embrace.

One of the officers stepped forward, his expression heavy with sorrow. He placed a steady hand on Marcus’s shoulder, grounding him in the chaos. “I’m sorry,” he said quietly. “We’re all sorry.”

The house was filled with grief — Latrice’s tears, Marcus’s cries, the officers’ solemn silence. Elijah’s sacrifice had reached them, and in that moment, Marcus’s vow to change because of

the baby collided with the crushing weight of loss, leaving him broken but held, shattered but not alone.

Chapter 19

Marcus walked with the sun beating down on him, each step heavier than the last. The streets were alive with chatter, cars rushing past, but he moved through it all like a ghost. His head throbbed, his body ached, and his mind replayed the night in jagged fragments — the laughter of the women, the clinking of glasses, the reckless spending, the way he let himself cross a line he swore he never would.

What have I done? he thought, dragging his feet along the cracked sidewalk. I betrayed her. I betrayed myself. And for what? For liquor. For pride. For a storm I couldn't control.

The hotel bill still burned in his pocket, the number etched into his mind: \$10,879. He had nothing left — no wallet, no phone, no dignity. Just the long walk home and the weight of his choices pressing harder with every block.

He imagined Latrice waiting, imagined her face when he walked through the door. Would she cry? Would she scream? Would she turn away? He rehearsed apologies in his head, but none of them felt strong enough. None of them could erase what

he had done.

By the time he reached the house, his chest was tight, his breath shallow. He pushed the door open, stumbling inside, his voice breaking before he could even see her.

“Latrice!” he called, louder than he meant to. “I’m sorry. I’m so sorry. I messed up. I—” His words tumbled out, desperate, raw, unpolished. “I shouldn’t have gone. I shouldn’t have done it. Please... forgive me.”

The house was quiet. He found her in the bedroom, sitting on the edge of the bed, pale and weary. She didn’t answer. Her silence was heavier than any scream could have been. She looked at him once, her eyes tired, then turned away, clutching the sheets as if they were the only thing holding her upright.

Marcus’s heart sank. He stepped closer, his voice softer now. “Latrice... talk to me.”

But she didn’t. She wasn’t well — he could see it in the way her shoulders slumped, the way her breath came shallow, the way she avoided his gaze.

Then his eyes fell to the nightstand.

The pregnancy test.

Two lines.

Marcus froze, the world tilting beneath him. His storm collided with silence, his reckless night crashing against the fragile truth sitting inches from his hand. He reached for it, his fingers trembling, his breath caught in his throat.

A child. His child.

The apology died in his mouth. He stood there, staring at the test, the weight of his betrayal pressing harder than ever. Latrice remained quiet, her body heavy with sickness, her eyes refusing to meet his.

Marcus’s storm had carried him through the night, but now it

left him stranded in the wreckage — facing the truth, facing her silence, facing the life he had already endangered before it even began.

Chapter 20

The living room was heavy with silence, broken only by Marcus's ragged breathing and Latrice's quiet sobs. The officers stood solemnly, their uniforms immaculate, their faces carved with grief. One of them stepped forward, his voice steady but low.

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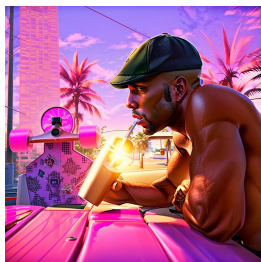
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About the Author

Absolutely — here's a compelling, cinematic bio that reflects your creative depth, emotional resilience, and your identity as a professional longboard dancer:

About the Author

Clayvon'te Broach is a survivor, memoirist, and visionary storyteller whose work blends raw emotional truth with cinematic intensity. As the founder of Boardwalk Clay Organization and the creator behind the Hidden Breath trilogy, Clayvon'te writes with a fierce commitment to authenticity, legacy, and transformation.

Outside the page, Clayvon'te is a professional longboard dancer — known for fluid, expressive movement that turns pavement into poetry. Their style is fearless and graceful, echoing the same rhythm found in their writing: bold, vulnerable, and unforgettable.

Whether crafting scenes of sacrifice or carving lines through city streets, Clayvon'te brings a rare blend of grit and grace to every story, every step, and every breath.

Also by Clayvon'te Broach